

"Sniffer dogs are the most valuable tool in security and detecting explosives."

RAJDEEP SINGH GILL, DIRECTOR, PUNJAB POLICE ACADEMY



memory of a particular scent and are not distracted in crowded situations. "The best part is that a canine detective cannot be subverted," says Sharma. The dog's nose has 225 million receptor cells as against five million in human beings, which means a 40-times higher ability to detect smells. A scientifically-trained dog can discriminate between a large number of explosives and other chemical substances—a quality that makes them an important tool in detecting even plastic-wrapped explosives that can escape metal detectors or even vapour-detection devices.

In India, German shepherds, labradors and dober-

mans are preferred as sniffers. Sourced from renowned dog breeders at three to six months of age, a pedigree dog is assigned a handler before being initiated in to a 32-week training at PPA. The first 12 weeks involve a variety of drills for basic obedience followed by four weeks to sharpen the sniffing skills and another 12 weeks to hone the explosive detection ability. "They are primed for sniffing four major groups of explosives buried up to three ft," says Sharma.

While the explosive sniffers are trained not to bark but wag their tail at detection of explosives, the narcotic sniffers and trackers are primed to bark when they discover a suspicious object or person. Each dog is used only for a single type of task.

The Punjab Police, which has a 121-strong dog contingent, the second biggest after BSF, for multiple VIP security and crime detection duties, plans to train another 160 dogs for deployment in the state. Director-General of Police N.P.S. Aulakh says, "We want to have more professional dogs to give a better sense of security to common people and deter the criminals." PPA is also mulling plans to train dogs for rescue, guard and patrol duties. Clearly, man's best friend for centuries is in greater demand in modern times. ■



dogs for the police in Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Haryana, the Rapid Action Force and the Special Security Bureau.

What has prompted security agencies to equip themselves with canine power is the efficacy and efficiency of trained dogs in detection of explosives. "Sniffer dogs are now reckoned as the most valuable tool in security drills against explosives," says PPA Director Rajdeep Singh Gill.

In the case of detection of hidden explosives, physical checks have been found to have 32 per cent reliability

DOG DETECTIVE: Sniffer dogs in a compartment (top) and at training and electronic gadgets account for 47 per cent, while sniffer dogs have 84 per cent reliability. A combination of all three has been found to have 94 per cent reliability in detecting explosives. Also, a dog can sniff-and-sanitise 15 sq ft per minute—much faster than humans or electronic gadgets.

Professional dogs have other inherent advantages. Besides extraordinary hearing and scent discrimination qualities, sniffer dogs are easy to train and maintain, easily portable, have a deep